

From caterpillar...

...to chrysalis...

...to butterfly!

A new view of nature

The transformation of a caterpillar into a butterfly was just one of the natural processes that Maria noticed. She didn't paint insects like they were in museums. Her creatures were full of life—growing, changing, and interacting with plants.

Trip to the tropics

Maria became well known for her paintings of European caterpillars.

After moving to the Netherlands, she was invited to see huge collections of tropical insects. However, the beautiful creatures had been dried out and pinned to boards. Maria longed to see them crawling, eating, breeding, and flying around. After years of hard work and planning, she set off on her very own scientific expedition—to Suriname, in South America.

In hot, humid Suriname, local people who knew the rainforest well helped Maria to row through waters full of snapping, alligator-like creatures called caiman, to discover spectacular animals. For two years, she marveled at spiders, snakes, and jewel-like insects. Back in the Netherlands, Maria turned her notes and sketches into a wonderful book—*Transformations of the Insects of Surinam*. Her work delighted kings and queens, and was studied by naturalists for centuries. But, perhaps Maria would be most pleased to know about the creatures named after her—a lizard, a spider, two beetles, and nine butterflies.

*This species of lizard, *Salvator merianae*, is named after Maria.*

